

Acme SaaS

Billing Policy & Customer Support Knowledge Base

Version 3.2 | Effective Date: January 1, 2025 | Support: billing@acmesaas.com

1. Subscription Plans & Pricing

Plan	Monthly Price	Annual Price	Users	Storage	Support
Starter	\$29/mo	\$290/yr (save 17%)	Up to 3	10 GB	Email only
Pro	\$79/mo	\$790/yr (save 17%)	Up to 15	100 GB	Email + Chat
Enterprise	Custom	Custom	Unlimited	Unlimited	Dedicated CSM

1.1 Billing Cycles

All subscriptions are billed at the start of each billing period — monthly on the signup date or annually on the renewal date. Bills are generated automatically and sent to the account's primary billing email.

- Monthly plans: Billed on the same calendar date each month (e.g., signed up on the 5th = billed every 5th).
- Annual plans: Billed once per year on the anniversary of signup. A renewal reminder email is sent 30 days before.
- Proration: Upgrades mid-cycle are charged the prorated difference immediately. Downgrades take effect at the next renewal date — no mid-cycle credit is issued.

1.2 Auto-Pay & Payment Methods

Acme SaaS uses Stripe as its payment processor. Accepted payment methods include Visa, Mastercard, American Express, and ACH bank transfers (US only). Auto-pay is enabled by default on all accounts.

- Auto-pay retry logic: If a payment fails, Stripe retries on Day 1, Day 3, Day 5, and Day 7.
- After 4 failed attempts, the subscription is suspended and a manual payment link is emailed to the account owner.
- ACH payments may take 3-5 business days to clear; the billing date is the initiation date, not the settlement date.

Note: If auto-pay is enabled and a late fee was still charged, it is almost always due to a card expiry, a bank decline for insufficient funds, or an address verification (AVS) mismatch. The system logs all decline reasons.

2. Refund Policy

2.1 Standard Refund Eligibility

Acme SaaS offers refunds under the following conditions:

- **Monthly plans:** Refunds are available within 7 calendar days of the charge date, provided the account has not consumed more than 20% of the monthly API quota or storage allocation.
- **Annual plans:** A prorated refund for unused months is available within 30 days of the annual renewal date. The first month is considered used and is non-refundable.
- **Duplicate charges:** Always refunded in full, typically within 3-5 business days after confirmation by the billing team.
- **Service outages:** If Acme SaaS experienced a verified outage exceeding 4 continuous hours in the billing period, affected customers are eligible for a prorated service credit (not a cash refund) applied to the next invoice.

2.2 Non-Refundable Situations

- Charges older than 30 days (monthly plans) or outside the 30-day renewal window (annual plans) are not eligible for a cash refund.
- Accounts that have used more than 80% of their plan's quota within the billing period.
- One-time add-on purchases (e.g., data migration services, professional onboarding) are non-refundable after the service has begun.
- Downgrade requests do not trigger a refund for the current billing period.

2.3 Refund Process & Timeline

Approved refunds are processed within 3-5 business days. The credit appears on the customer's statement within 5-10 business days depending on the card issuer. ACH refunds may take up to 7 business days.

Note: Billing agents must never promise a refund directly. All refund eligibility is confirmed by the billing team after reviewing account usage data. Use the phrase: 'I will flag this for review by our billing team and you will receive an update within 1 business day.'

3. Late Fees & Payment Failures

3.1 Late Fee Schedule

A late fee is applied when a payment remains outstanding after all four automatic retry attempts have failed and the account has been suspended for more than 3 business days.

Days Past Due	Late Fee Applied	Account Status
0 – 7 days	No fee (retry window)	Active
8 – 14 days	\$15 flat fee	Suspended
15 – 30 days	\$15 + 1.5% of balance	Suspended
30+ days	Referred to collections	Terminated

3.2 Late Fee Waivers

Late fees may be waived under these circumstances:

- First-time late fee: Customers with no prior payment issues are eligible for a one-time courtesy waiver. Limit: once per account lifetime.
- Bank or processor error: If a bank decline was caused by a verified processor error (not customer error), the fee is waived automatically upon confirmation.
- Auto-pay was incorrectly disabled by a system bug: If engineering confirms the bug, the fee is waived and the customer is notified.
- Documented medical or financial hardship: Escalate to the billing team manager with documentation; waiver at manager discretion.

Note: Agents cannot waive fees directly. To request a waiver, flag the ticket with tag [FEE-WAIVER-REQUEST] and include the reason. The billing team responds within 1 business day.

4. Cancellation & Downgrade Policy

4.1 How to Cancel

Customers may cancel their subscription at any time from Settings > Billing > Cancel Subscription. Cancellations take effect at the end of the current billing period. Access remains active until that date.

- Monthly plans: Cancel anytime; access and billing stop at the end of the current month.
- Annual plans: Cancel anytime; access continues until the end of the paid year. No partial refund is issued unless within the 30-day refund window (see Section 2.1).
- Immediate cancellation: Available upon request from the billing team for exceptional circumstances. Subject to refund eligibility rules.

4.2 Post-Cancellation Billing

If a customer is charged after cancellation, the charge is almost always caused by one of the following:

- The cancellation was initiated after the billing date for that cycle (cancellations are not retroactive).

- A secondary workspace or seat add-on was not cancelled separately before the main subscription.
- A bug in the cancellation flow (rare; requires engineering investigation).

In any of the above cases, the customer should contact support with their cancellation confirmation email. The billing team will investigate and issue a refund if the charge was in error.

4.3 Downgrade Policy

Downgrades (e.g., Pro to Starter) take effect at the start of the next billing cycle. Customers retain Pro-tier access until that date. No credit is issued for unused time on the higher tier.

Note: If a customer downgrades and their current data (users, storage) exceeds the lower plan's limits, they must reduce usage before the downgrade takes effect or the downgrade will be blocked automatically.

5. Incorrect Charges & Billing Disputes

5.1 Common Causes of Incorrect Charges

- Duplicate charge: Caused by a double-click on the payment button or a rare processor error. Always refundable.
- Wrong plan amount: Usually caused by a plan change not reflecting correctly. Requires billing team to compare charge history with plan logs.
- Unexpected annual charge: Occurs when a customer did not see the renewal reminder email (check spam). Within the 30-day window, prorated refund available.
- Charge after cancellation: See Section 4.2.

5.2 Dispute Resolution Steps

When a customer reports an incorrect charge, the support agent should:

- Step 1: Acknowledge the concern and assure the customer their issue is being taken seriously.
- Step 2: Ask for the charge amount, date, and last 4 digits of the card used (if available).
- Step 3: Flag the ticket for the billing team with all collected details. Do not attempt to process a refund directly.
- Step 4: Inform the customer they will receive a billing team response within 1 business day.
- Step 5: If the customer threatens a chargeback, do not discourage them, but note that Acme SaaS's dispute resolution process typically resolves issues faster (1 business day vs. 30-90 days for bank chargebacks).

6. Common Support Scenarios & Recommended Responses

6.1 'I was charged twice this month'

Classify as duplicate charge. Ask for charge date and amount. Flag for billing team with [DUPLICATE-CHARGE] tag. Inform the customer that duplicate charges are always refunded in full (3-5 business days) once confirmed. Do not promise the refund before billing team confirms.

6.2 'I got a late fee but auto-pay is enabled'

Auto-pay being enabled does not guarantee successful payment. Common causes: expired card, insufficient funds, AVS mismatch, or bank decline. Check if the customer received a payment failure email. Advise them to verify their card details in Settings > Billing > Payment Methods. If the card was valid and the decline appears to be a processor error, flag for a potential fee waiver with tag [FEE-WAIVER-REQUEST].

6.3 'I cancelled but still got billed'

Ask for the cancellation confirmation email date. If cancellation was confirmed before the billing date, this is likely a billing error — flag for the billing team with [POST-CANCEL-CHARGE] tag. If the cancellation was after the billing date, explain that cancellations are not retroactive and the charge covers the current period already billed.

6.4 'Your company scammed me'

De-escalate calmly. Acknowledge frustration without admitting fault. Do not match the customer's tone. Say: 'I completely understand how frustrating unexpected charges can be. I want to make this right. Can you tell me which charge is concerning you?' Treat as a billing dispute and follow Section 5.2 steps.

6.5 'Can I get a refund for last month?'

Check the refund eligibility criteria from Section 2.1. Monthly plans: within 7 days and usage under 20%. Annual plans: within 30 days of renewal. If eligible window has passed, explain the policy clearly and empathetically. Never say 'you are not eligible' without checking; always flag for billing team review. Use: 'I'll flag this for review by our billing team.'

7. Escalation Guidelines

Escalate to the billing team (billing@acmesaas.com / internal Jira board) whenever:

- A charge needs to be confirmed as duplicate or erroneous.
- A refund needs to be approved or processed.

- A late fee waiver is being requested.
- A post-cancellation charge is disputed.
- The customer has threatened a chargeback or legal action.
- An account has been suspended and the customer is a key account (Enterprise tier).

Standard SLA: Billing team responds within 1 business day. Enterprise accounts: within 4 business hours.

*This document is confidential and intended for Acme SaaS support staff only. Last updated: January 2025.
Questions? Contact the Billing Operations team at billing-ops@acmesaas.com.*